WHEN WE MEET

COMMUNITY DEVELOPMENT IN MOTION

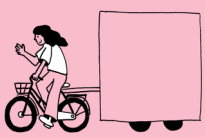








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ABSTRACT

In a time of increasing polarization, conflicts, and spatial inequality, working towards a socially sustainable society is crucial to overcome existing and future challenges. This thesis explores how architectural design can foster inclusivity, community well-being, and the generation of social capital by creating spaces for encounters and fostering community engagement. With Umeå, Sweden, as the local context, the study critically analyzes municipal strategies for social sustainability and investigates the relationship between the physical environment and social processes. Drawing from theories of social capital, spatial justice, and participatory urbanism, the research highlights the importance of accessible, non-commercial meeting spaces and community engagement. The project consists of two key spatial explorations: the Community Wagon, a mobile architectural artifact for social engagement and dialogue, and The Hub, a movable structure designed to activate local neighborhoods and act as a catalyst for community engagement. Both interventions are grounded in the belief that inclusive urban development must be co-created, locally responsive, and engaging the community. By combining theory, policy analysis, field experiments, and speculative design, this thesis argues that architectural practice can, and must, support democratic, equitable, and socially generative spaces within the urban environment.

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TABLE OF CONTENT

RESEARCH QUESTION 4
INTRODUCTION 5

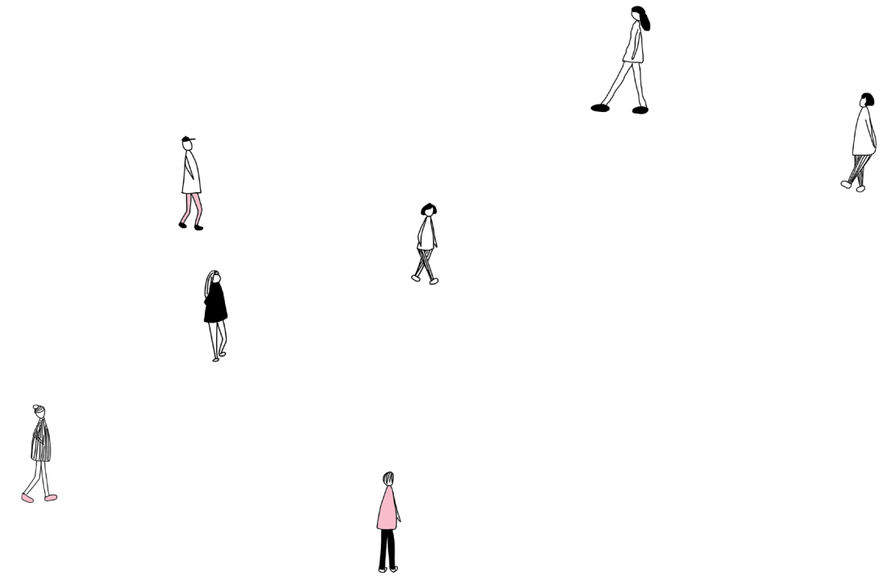
01. //WHY WE MEET 6
SOCIAL SUSTAINABILITY 6
ANOTHER FORM OF CAPITAL 9
GEOGRAPHIES OF ENCOUNTERS 10
BEYOND ENCOUNTERS 12
SOCIAL SUSTAINABILITY IN UMEÅ 14
SÅ STÅR DET TILL 14
THE SOCIAL OBJECTIVE 18

02. //WHERE WE MEET 22
SOCIAL INTERVENTIONS 22
THE COMMUNITY WAGON 24
NOTES FROM EXPLORATION 26
SUMMARY OF FINDINGS 28

03. //WHEN WE MEET 30
THE HUB 30
MANAGING THE HUB 34

CONCLUSION 38
REFERENCES 40





Geographies of encounters:

> *A conceptual term that describes the places, spaces, and spatial processes through which people meet and interact, particularly across lines of difference, within the urban environment.*

RESEARCH QUESTION

What architectural design strategies and interventions can we use to contribute to a socially sustainable society, and how can we foster inclusivity, equality, and community well-being within the built environment in Umeå?

Aim: To explore how urban spaces can be reimagined to foster social interaction, inclusivity, and the regeneration of social capital, using Umeå as a case study.

Objectives:

- To critically analyze Umeå Municipality's approach to social sustainability in relation to global and national research, policies, and strategies.
- To explore how theories of social capital and spatial justice can inform socially sustainable design in urban environments.
- To analyze the role of meeting places in promoting community well-being, inclusion, and everyday social interaction.
- To test and reflect on small-scale, participatory design interventions as tools for community engagement and local place-making.

INTRODUCTION

With rising challenges like increasing polarisation, conflicts, criminality, and decreasing mental and physical health, there is an urgent need to build a more socially sustainable society. In the wake of the neoliberal agenda with market-driven governance, we find a society strained by austerity politics where financial gains and commercial interests have guided the development (Theodore 2020). With urban centers planned and dominated by commercial spaces and high-profile projects driving gentrification processes, the physical environment becomes a reflection of the capitalism-centered ideology (Yarina 2017; Scott 2019). At the same time, privatization and the weakening welfare systems result in neglect and enclosures of common and shared spaces (Blomqvist 2004). This leaves us with the question of how to achieve a coherent social objective in today's urban environment.

The city is more than a collection of individuals and physical structures, it is a multifaceted arena for encounters and processes that encompasses a multitude of cultures, backgrounds, educational levels, and ages. A place where social challenges become tangible and visible. The city is where we meet each other, or not. Urban environment in its physical appearance has the power to influence social processes by enabling social encounters or by creating physical barriers that limit social development (Klinenberg 2018; Regeringskansliet 2021; Rosenhall et al. 2017). To build social relationships, trust, understanding, and tolerance for our differences, we need to be able to meet each other. Attractive spaces where we want to spend time and feel a sense of ownership are essential in a socially sustainable environment, as is having the right to participate and influence decisions affecting you and your surroundings (Formas 2011). Promoting social sustainability requires strategies focused on inclusion, social cohesion, community development, and participation across multiple sectors to ensure viable urban social infrastructure (Barron et al. 2023; Boström 2012; United Nations n.d.).

With Umeå's ambition to reach the goal of 200.000 inhabitants by the year 2050, the question is how the municipality plans to incorporate agendas for inclusion, equality, and the generation of social capital in the built environment to promote socially sustainable development. The urban development in Umeå during the recent decades has aligned with the global trends towards a consumerism-centered development (Almqvist 2013). Achieving social sustainability will require a comprehensive effort where soft values and a long-term social perspective are prioritized over financial gains. Comprehensive plans and urban strategies at a city scale need to be complemented by local strategies and participatory processes to enable interventions that can improve the local environment and ensure accessible social infrastructure.

Based on this theoretical background, this thesis aims to explore the possibilities of creating urban meeting spaces and strategies for local community development in Umeå with the mission of creating a more socially sustainable city.

01.

//WHY WE MEET

SOCIAL SUSTAINABILITY
- A theoretical background

Global communities have better access to education, health care, employment, and overall access to service today than previous generations. Unfortunately the gains are fragile and unequally distributed. We are living in a reality where many people are struggling to manage their living costs, battling deteriorating mental health, being excluded, discriminated against or facing an everyday life alone in social isolation. Polarization, division and inequality are rising and exclusion and vulnerability are worsened by persistent shocks, conflicts, and climate disasters (Barron et al. 2023). We are confronted daily with images of violence that claim innocent lives and world leaders whose rhetoric promotes anything but inclusion and equality. Public institutions are closing, welfare is eroding, and income inequalities is increasing, making the rich richer and the poor poorer (SVT 2022). The development of a socially sustainable society is crucial as well as urgent, not only for the individual's health and well-being but also to meet the global challenges and achieve the changes required in the economic system and society at large to realize sustainable development.

The term social sustainability was introduced in the Brundtland Commission's report '*Our Common Future*' published by the World Commission on Environment and Development in 1987. The report defines sustainable development as '*meeting the needs of the present without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs*'. The commission emphasized that sustainable development encompasses not only economic and environmental aspects but also social and cultural dimensions. However, the social pillar of sustainable development has been kept in the periphery in favor of economic growth and, later, environmental sustainability. It was not until the United Nations Millennium Development Goals in the year 2000 that social concepts like inclusion, voice, empowerment, equity, and gender equality were widely included in the debate about sustainability (Barron et al. 2023). The 2030 Agenda for Sustainable Development, adopted by all United Nations Member States in 2015, further recognizes that strategies for combating climate change must be parallel to the work with social and economic progress (United Nations n.d.).

Social sustainability is a complex field that involves both non-physical and physical factors, and despite its relatively long history, lacks a coherent definition. Rasouli and Kumarasuriyar (2016) categorize key aspects of social sustainability into macro- and micro-level dimensions, ranging from the basic level of physical well-being to quality of life and equity while Boström (2012) summarises the social pillar of sustainable development to include both the social goals of sustainable development as well as procedural aspects to achieve the development goals. The World Bank, in turn, emphasizes four key components in social sustainability: social cohesion, inclusion, resilience, and process legitimacy (Barron et al. 2023). These components are complemented by the United Nations Universal Declaration of Human Rights (1948), which underscores fundamental rights such as equality, freedom, housing, and education. Another aspect is the sustainability of communities, which relates to the collective aspects of social life. Dempsey et al. (2011) describe five dimensions of interrelated measurable aspects of community sustainability: social interaction/ social networks in the community, participation in collective groups and networks, community stability, pride/sense of place, and safety and security.

The aim of this paper is not to summarize existing research to create a unified definition of social sustainability; the field is too extensive. Instead, the focus of this thesis lies in examining how the different aspects of social sustainability relate to the physical environment and how the architectural profession can use this knowledge in the planning and design of urban spaces to promote social sustainability. Working towards social sustainability requires comprehensive efforts and a long-term perspective. There is no quick or simple solution and actions must be implemented on multiple levels, including everything from actively promoting safety and trust within communities to developing inclusive public spaces and activities that bring together people from different backgrounds and social groups. Today, more than half of the world's population lives in urban areas, and the number is expected to increase to more than double by the year 2050 (World Bank Group, n.d). Cities are more than just a physical collection of buildings, they are multifaceted places where people with different socioeconomic conditions, backgrounds, education levels, cultures, and ethnicities meet, live, and influence each other. It is an arena for ideas, innovation, and social exchange, but also where inequalities, segregation, and exclusion are made visible. Un-Habitat states that the lines of division and exclusion in urban areas have increased, driven by factors such as economic disparities, racial and ethnic segregation, housing policies, and unequal access to education, employment, and public services. They further argue that the success or failure of social integration and inclusion are primarily felt at the city level, and that "to build inclusive societies, we must focus on creating inclusive cities" (Halfani & Toner 2008).

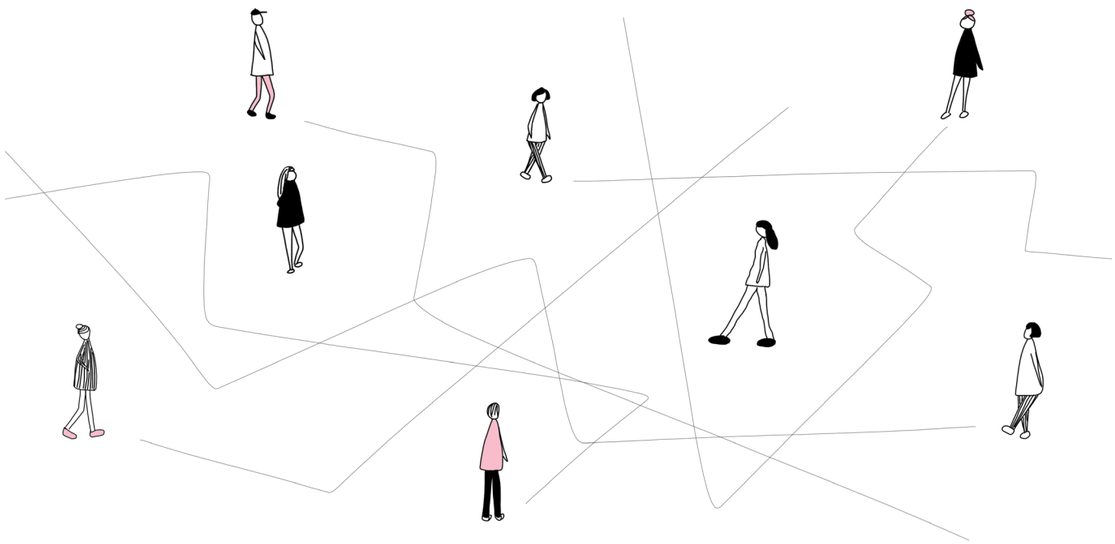


Fig 1. *Illustration*

Non physical aspects	Physical aspects
Clothing	Attractive public spaces
Community cohesion	Access to social infrastructure
Cultural tradition	Green spaces
Democracy	Housing
Diversity	Meeting places
Education	Walkability
Employment	
Food	
Health	
Identity	
Integration	
Safety	
Sense of place	
Social capital	
Social connections	
Social justice and equity	
Social relationships	
Process legitimacy	
Participation	
Quality of life	

Fig.2. *Factors of urban social sustainability. Factors identified in literature review. Sources: Barron et al. 2023; Boström 2012; Dempsey et al. 2011; Emmelin & Eriksson 2012; Eriksson et al. 2021; Rasouli & Kumarasuriyar 2016; Regeringskansliet 2021; United Nations 1948;*

ANOTHER FORM OF CAPITAL

- The fabric of belonging

An important aspect of our ability to adapt to societal change, build strong communities, and promote social cohesion is *social capital*. In 2000, Robert Putnam released his book '*Bowling Alone: The Collapse and Revival of American Community*' in which he argued that there has been a decline in community cohesion and civic engagement across America since the 1950s. What Putnam observed was how social capital declined as digitalisation changed the way we interact. Instead of actively participating in community life and social activities, families began gathering at home in front of the TV. The exact definition of the term social capital has been debated by many scholars, among them Bourdieu (2002), Coleman (1988), and Putnam (1995). Putnam refers to social capital as features of social organization such as networks, norms, and social trust that facilitate coordination and cooperation for mutual benefit, while Bourdieu places social capital among economic- and cultural capital which can be exchanged, maintained and reinforced, highlighting that all capital contributes to the reproduction of social hierarchies. Coleman and Putnam regard social capital as a positive resource open to all groups and communities, while Bourdieu refers to social capital as a way of preserving class advantage. Today, the general definition of social capital is '*the interconnected network of relationships within a society and the level of generalized trust and reciprocity that characterize these ties to allow citizens to overcome collective action problems more effectively*' (Barron et al. 2023; Poteyeva 2024; Stolle & Hooghe 2003). In other words, social capital is our social networks, our social support, our opportunities to participate in community life, and the degree of social cohesion in our local environment. It is something that we build together in social exchange with each other. Putnam (2000) distinguishes between two types of social capital, bonding and bridging. Bonding social capital refers to strong ties between people who are alike, such as family, close friends, or members of the same community. Bridging social capital involves weaker ties that connect individuals across different social, ethnic, or economic groups. These connections are essential for exchanging ideas, building trust between communities and fostering broader social cohesion. Putnam argues that both forms are necessary. Bonding capital strengthens the bonds and identity within groups, while bridging capital connects society as a whole. Social capital is tightly linked with social sustainability and can be seen as a means for how processes of social sustainability could be developed and assessed (Dempsey et al. 2011). A high level of social capital can benefit coexistence in societies, promoting tolerance and acceptance of differences, which in turn makes it easier to collaborate and engage in civic action (Alfredsson & Wijkman 2014; Stolle & Hooghe 2003; Larsen et al. 2004). It is also linked to increased community resilience in crisis (Klinenberg 2018). To build social capital, we need to see and interact with each other, making the physical environment an important element in the development of social sustainability.

GEOGRAPHIES OF ENCOUNTERS

- The production of social capital

The physical environment has the power to influence social processes by enabling social encounters or by creating or reinforcing physical barriers that limit social development (Klinenberg 2018; Regeringskansliet 2021; Rosenhall et. al. 2017). Klinenberg (2018) uses the term *social infrastructure* when referring to these physical nodes where encounters take place and social capital is produced. Klinenbergs definition of social infrastructure is similar to what Oldenburg (1999) refers to as third places, the social surroundings that are not the work or the home. Social infrastructure includes spaces such as libraries, schools, playgrounds, swimming pools, parks, sidewalks, and streets. Both Klinenberg and Oldenburg emphasize the importance of physical meeting places and eye-to-eye conversations to form and strengthen social connections. The importance of social infrastructure is further strengthened by Zahnow and Corcoran (2024) and Blokland and Nast (2014), who explain that everyday encounters with other people have an important role in individual social well-being. The studies show that public familiarity, to recognize and to be recognized in local spaces, creates a comfort zone that invokes a feeling of belonging, even though the ties are superficial and fluid. The planning and development of our physical environment can therefore influence social processes and help foster integration, physical and mental health, safety and security, trust, and cohesion (Regeringskansliet 2021). Another strong advocate for the importance of physical meeting places is Marcus Miessen. Miessen (2024) argues that physical proximity and the ability to gather in a shared spatial environment strongly influence our capacity for critical debates, social skills, and the ability to engage in productive confrontations and challenges. The physical space enables a social sphere and creates opportunities for dialogue, and Miessen emphasizes that places such as libraries, cultural centers, and community centers are essential to enable this social exchange to happen. We must develop our urban environments to facilitate geographies of encounters, places where people from different backgrounds can meet, interact, and build connections.

In an increasingly socially and culturally heterogeneous society, it is important to establish meeting places where bridging social capital can be generated, and where people from different socio-economic and socio-demographic backgrounds can cross paths (Rosenhall et. al. 2017). Residents in low-income and segregated neighborhoods are often more excluded from the community and are experiencing the consequences of social unsustainability, such as higher crime rates, lower educational levels, and drug abuse (Boverket 2023). Neighbourhoods with a large proportion of foreign-born residents are also associated with a decreased likelihood of having a high level of social capital (Eriksson et. al. 2021). Encouraging people to visit other areas than the one they reside in, especially areas with different levels of social capital, is important to create bridging social capital between individuals from diverse socioeconomic and cultural backgrounds. Establishing connections and enabling flows of people between different neighborhoods can counteract spatial segregation (Dahlin 2015).

The Swedish government (2021) states in its report 'Den hala tvålen' that there is no generic solution for social sustainability in urban planning and development. The work must be shaped by the unique characteristics, conditions, and needs of each place, which requires strategies to be adapted to the specific context. Emmelin and Eriksson (2012) highlight five key measures in the work of generating neighbourhood social capital: Facilitating social interaction by creating 'third places' for meeting and engagement, investing in attractive green and recreational areas, addressing the need for safety and security, improving the reputation of disadvantaged areas and balancing bonding and bridging social capital to strengthen community cohesion. While the physical environment can have an important role, we must be humble about the fact that architecture and urban planning are not a universal cure for social issues. Ekologigruppen (2019) emphasizes that we must recognize the limitations that the physical environment has on social sustainability. The reality often shows that, despite good intentions to build diverse and inclusive urban environments, new developments are often so expensive that only a limited group can afford to live there thus being unavailable for a large number of people.

”Architecture can’ t force people to connect; it can only plan the crossing points, remove barriers, and make the meeting places useful and attractive.”

- D.S Brown (Jordana 2011)

BEYOND ENCOUNTERS

- Practices of participation and right to the city

Henri Lefebvre (1991) states that '*(Social) space is a (social) product … the space thus produced also serves as a tool of thought and of action … in addition to being a means of production it is also a means of control, and hence of domination, of power*'. In this regard, Spaces, therefore, are not neutral but can reflect and reinforce existing social relationships and power structures. David Harvey (2003) argues that urban development under neoliberalism prioritizes capital accumulation above everything else, leading to increasing class divisions and inequality. He states, '*To live under capitalism is to accept or submit to that bundle of rights necessary for endless capital accumulation*'. Harvey critiques the lack of alignment between policies affecting spatial forms and the social processes within cities, and argues that we should ideally be able to harmonize these policies to achieve some coherent social objective (Harvey 2009). The city has been transformed into an arena for consumerism and is, more often than not, lacking spaces for activities that are not driven by the accumulation of capital. The right to dwell and occupy physical spaces in the city is therefore not always granted. Today, in many urban environments, the property rights of the owners exceed the rights of the inhabitants to occupy the urban space (Purcell 2014). In this context, the challenges of promoting social sustainability within the framework of neoliberal agendas and austerity politics become increasingly difficult. Despite the need for a social dimension in the urban development process, physical planning is largely characterized by market-driven governance, which, among other things, leads to a more short-term focus as well as a focus on values that can be quantified in economic calculations (Regeringskansliet 2021). Investments in affordable housing and social infrastructures such as green spaces, community centers, and libraries cannot be measured directly in economic gains and are therefore not prioritized.

As David Harvey (2003) states; '*… the right to the city … is not merely a right of access to what the property speculators and state planners define, but an active right to make the city different, to shape it more in accord with our heart's desire*', and calls for a new urban common with a public sphere of active democratic participation. Similarly, Miessen (2024) states that '*The change in our cities under neoliberal government with an emphasis on the tertiary and commercial sector has contributed to increasing social- and spatial inequalities as well as a weakening of the public sphere and the loss of political agency. It is critical to maintain spaces of gathering and embrace spatial development as a collective process rather than treating spatial production as an autonomous top-down process*'. Miessen advocates for a more participatory and democratic approach to architecture and spatial development to counteract the consequences of neoliberal governance, and that all individuals, regardless of their expertise, can take part in the discussion and development work. He states that participation, in itself, is an object of innovation (Miessen 2024). Having the opportunity to be involved in the early stages of the development process has proven to be of significance for sustainable results. Local engagement and participation increase the motivation and endurance for long-term development and lasting change (Formas 2011). Creating local engagement in urban development projects can also have a positive effect on the social capital and community cohesion. One example is an intervention conducted in 2003, in three neighborhoods in Portland, Oregon, which aimed to enhance community participation in urban renewal and engage residents in the co-creation of more attractive public spaces. The project led to improvements in individual mental health, a stronger sense of community, and increased social capital (Semenza, March & Bontempo 2007). A key factor in the success of the project was the emphasis on community engagement. By identifying key local stakeholders and tailoring the intervention to neighborhood-specific needs, the initiative not only improved the physical environment but also fostered new relationships and strengthened community involvement. This aligns with Block's (2018) statement that community building requires requires consideration and knowledge about the local inhabitants, conditions and organizations. However, the reality is that participation and community engagement often occur at a low level and decision-making rarely extends beyond the corridors of power (IVA 2017). Working toward social sustainability requires increased municipal engagement in dialogue, local anchoring and careful consideration of who is invited to participate in the discussion (Regeringskansliet 2021)



Fig 3. *Collage*

SOCIAL SUSTAINABILITY IN UMEÅ

- A municipal perspective

Building on the theoretical foundation established in the previous section, we can begin to understand the mechanisms that shape social processes in urban environments. However, how do municipalities and public institutions interpret and apply these ideas in their development efforts? To meaningfully address this question, it is necessary to examine how social sustainability is conceptualized, strategized, and implemented at the municipal level. This chapter focuses on Umeå, Sweden, as a case study for exploring how these processes unfold in practice. By analyzing Umeå's planning documents, policy frameworks, and overarching strategies, the aim is to evaluate how efforts toward socially sustainable development are translated into spatial and social realities.

Umeå municipality is characterized by a high rate of social capital and general trust among its inhabitants. In comparison to many other Swedish cities, Umeå has relatively low crime rates, low perceived insecurity, and a high trust in authorities with no neighborhoods that is classified as '*socially vulnerable*' (Umeå kommun 2024; Umeå kommun 2020). The region has also consistently had high rankings on the EU Regional Social Progress Index (European Commission n.d.). A study by Eriksson et al. (2021), where Umeå's social capital was measured in 2006 and 2020, shows an overall progress of the social capital within the municipality but also differences in the distribution between Umeås neighborhoods (see fig 4). Even though Umeå has relatively high levels of social capital and social progress, the municipality reports challenges with tendencies toward increased organized crime and rising domestic violence. Families are also facing increased challenges due to the economic setback over the last years, and school dropout rates are rising, especially among young girls (Umeå kommun 2024). Umeå is one of Sweden's fastest-growing cities, with the ambition to grow to 200.000 inhabitants by the year 2050. The challenge, however, is how to accomplish this goal sustainably.

SÅ STÅR DET TILL

- Social capital in Umeå's neighbourhoods

In 2019, Umeå Municipality launched an initiative to explore the social fabric within the city's neighborhoods. Using a bicycle, the municipal representatives traveled across Umeå to engage residents in dialogue, gathering their thoughts and perspectives on both their local community and its physical environment. The investigation resulted in the report 'Umeås stadsdelar - Så står det till', which describes each of umeås neighborhoods from a social perspective with emphasis on social capital and sustainability factors. The report provides an in-depth description of the different qualities, strengths, and, to some extent, development potential of Umeå's neighborhoods (Umeå Kommun 2020).

During the citizen dialogue, the inhabitants were asked to place red dots for places they didn't like or felt were unsafe and unattractive, and green dots for places they liked, felt safe, and attractive. The inhabitants also answered questions regarding what they would miss if they moved from the area and their wishes for the neighbourhood in the next 20 years (Umeå kommun 2022). When comparing the mapping from the

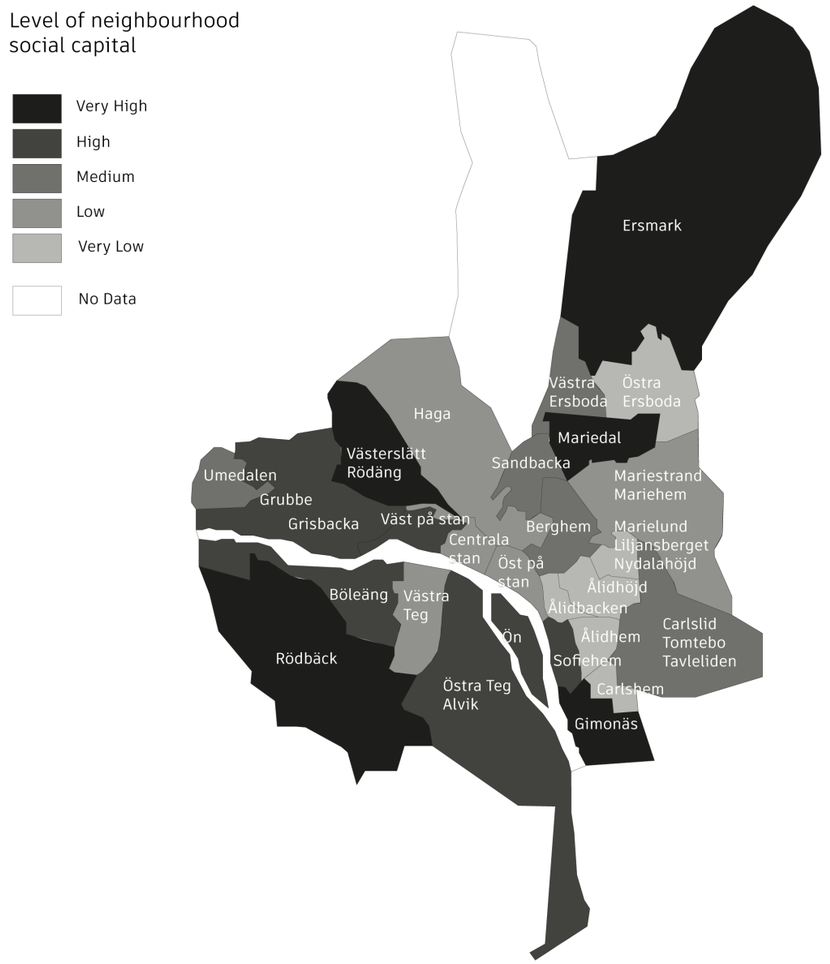
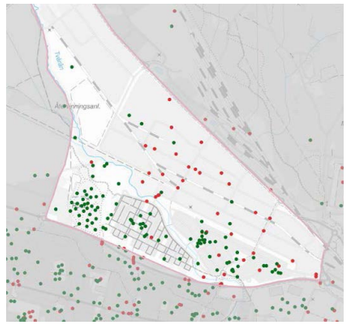
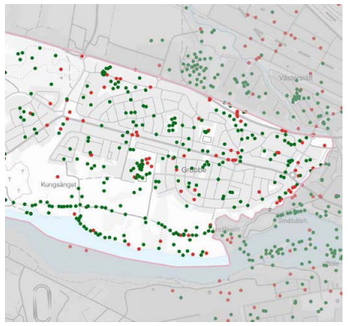


Fig 4. *Level of neighbourhood social capital in Umeå. Source; Eriksson et al. 2021*

HIGH SOCIAL CAPITAL

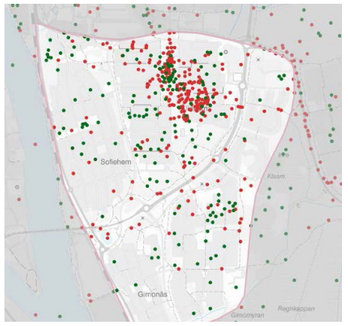


Västerslätt

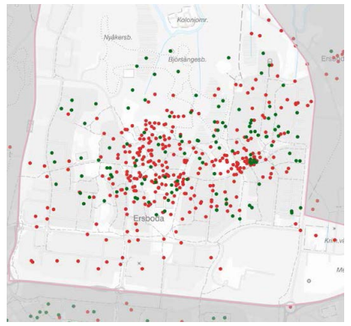


Grubbe

LOW SOCIAL CAPITAL



Ålidhem



Ersboda

Fig 5. *Result from citizen dialogue in relation to level of social capital. Source; Umeå Kommun 2020; Eriksson et al. 2021*

citizen dialogue with the study of social capital in Umeå by Eriksson et al. (2021), there are correlations between the level of social capital and the number of red or green dots in an area.

An analysis of the mapping shows that more spaces have been marked as unsafe or unattractive in neighbourhoods with lower social capital compared to areas with higher social capital (see fig.5). When comparing Ålidhem, which is a neighbourhood with a low level of social capital, with Västerslätt, which has a high level of social capital, there is a clear difference in the number of red dots in both areas. In ålidhem, the red dots are more frequent and gathered in clusters, versus Västerslätt, where the amount red dots is lower and more scattered. The same tendencies can be observed in other areas, such as Ersboda, compared to Grubbe. This observation implies a relationship between the physical environment and social capital in Umeå's neighborhoods, and could be an indication that local interventions and strategies are needed to improve the environment in the neighborhoods with lower social capital. However, a complicating factor is that many red dots in low-social-capital areas were placed by non-residents. In Ålidhem, 47% of red dots came from non-residents, and in Ersboda, 58%. This raises questions about which negative perceptions stem from the actual physical environment and which stem from the reputation of the neighbourhood. To gain clearer insights, a new study focusing specifically on residents' experiences of their local environment could be valuable. However, improving a neighborhood's reputation should be seen as a vital part of social sustainability, a measure highlighted in Umeå Municipality's report (2020) and the work of Emmelin and Eriksson (2012).

The report 'Så står det till' places a strong emphasis on the positive qualities of Umeå's neighborhoods. Pernilla Helmersson, urban planner at Umeå municipality, describes the work with the report: '*When we were out conducting dialogues in the neighborhoods, we noticed a palpable sense of pride—residents were proud of their district. This pride was consistent across all areas. We wanted to capture that in the descriptions of each neighborhood—the so-called 'basic courses.' We aimed for residents to recognize themselves and feel proud, and that's what we strived to convey in our portrayals of the different districts.*'

While this approach helps highlight community strengths, it also risks presenting an overly polished picture, one where challenges are glossed over by idealized descriptions. In that sense, the report can at times resemble a real estate brochure. For a more transparent and accurate portrayal of the current state, it's important to also acknowledge the issues. Doing so could create space for constructive dialogue and opens the door to meaningful improvements within each neighborhood.

THE SOCIAL OBJECTIVE

- Policies, strategies and implementation

Umeå Municipality is actively working to implement strategies for social sustainability in urban development and city planning. The guiding documents for this work are Umeå Municipality's comprehensive plan, planning strategy, and program for socially sustainable development. A central aspect of Umeå's urban planning is the planned transition from a large city (stor stad) to a metropolitan area (storstad) by 2050. This goal permeates the municipality's work and, in many ways, guides the city's future development at all levels.

Umeå municipality has chosen to actively engage in social sustainability efforts, focusing on how social capital can be managed and developed in the city, and is including the social perspective in its plans and strategies. This section will examine the strategies employed by Umeå municipality and compare them with the theoretical background presented in the previous chapter.

In 2016, Umeå municipality appointed a commission for sustainable development with the mission to analyze differences in living conditions and to propose relevant interventions and strategies for socially sustainable development. Based on the work conducted by the commission, together with the city's strategic gender equality efforts and crime prevention, the municipality developed a 'Program for social sustainability' that aims to reduce growing inequalities by actively working with communities to secure good living conditions for all (Umeå kommun 2025). The program emphasizes sustainable growth, the enhancement of public spaces, and equitable access to housing by working with overarching structures that foster integration and balanced urban development. A primary goal is overcoming physical and social barriers to public spaces by improving accessibility to parks, green areas, libraries, and service centers. Furthermore, the strategy prioritizes socially sustainable housing policies, addressing challenges such as housing shortages, high costs, and homelessness, which in higher grades impact the more vulnerable population in the society, such as single individuals, families with children, and seniors (Umeå Kommun 2025).

In addressing social sustainability, Umeå municipality has consciously chosen to work from 'The whole city'- perspective, as they call it, where the emphasis lies on a larger scale perspective instead of local interventions, focusing on bridging barriers between neighbourhoods, optimizing the communication infrastructure, and creating mixed-use neighbourhoods (Umeå Kommun 2018). These broad strategies align with current research but risk falling short because they overlook the local perspective needed to transform areas into spaces that encourage social interaction and encounters. As noted earlier, there isn't a generic solution for community building and fostering social connections within the built environment; success depends on the local context, organizations, and residents. Building mixed-use neighborhoods and promoting bridging social capital by removing physical barriers and encouraging interaction between areas is only one part of the solution. Another problematic aspect of Umeå municipality's strategies is the ambiguous definition of public spaces and meeting places. The municipality's planning strategy (2024) emphasizes the growing importance of public spaces, stating: '*The compact city makes public spaces increasingly important. Public spaces should be designed to create attractive, safe, and engaging places for recreation and greenery. These areas should be vibrant with movement throughout the day and across all seasons. A dynamic public space contributes to urban vitality, enhances safety, creates a welcoming atmosphere for visitors, and strengthens the city's commercial and service sectors*'. The value of public spaces is clearly emphasized. However, the text continues with the statement: '*Public spaces are difficult to follow up on in terms of quality and investments in these areas, as it is not specified what these spaces actually are.*' In other words, the plan provides us with a description of how public spaces should be designed to be attractive, engaging, and recreational, but does not specify what a public space is or how its development and investment should be measured. Both the comprehensive plan and the Social Sustainability Program Report repeatedly acknowledge a lack of clarity on what truly constitutes a public space or a meeting place within the city. The municipality recognizes the important role of green areas and meeting places in fostering social capital and social sustainability, but the lack of a clear definition and structured development process raises concerns about the

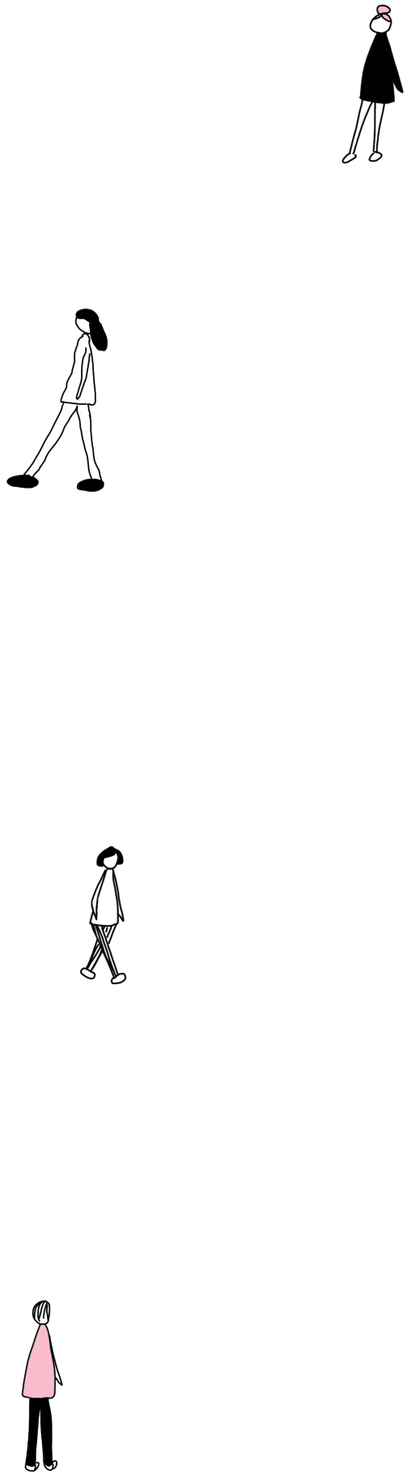


Fig 6. *Illustration*

strategy's implementation and effectiveness. Without being able to define what public spaces and meeting places encompass, it can prove challenging to evaluate progress or ensure that investments are aligned with the intended social outcomes.

Another critical factor is the impact of seasonal changes on public space, especially in northern regions like Umeå. During the winter, the public spaces are unavailable due to snow and cold weather. Relying on the development of outdoor parks and public areas overlooks the fact that these spaces are inaccessible for a large part of the year. The social life cannot only be focused on the warmer season and outdoor social spaces. There is a need for open and accessible meeting places where people can gather regardless of season and without the constraints of consumptive access to indoor spaces. In the city center, Umeå City Library and the square inside the Utopia shopping center are two of the rare spaces where people can gather without the need to consume. The reality in the neighbourhoods in umeå is no different. Some exceptions include the local libraries, Ersboda Folkets Hus, and Klossen in Ålidhem. Occasionally, housing associations may provide bookable community rooms, but access to those spaces depends on where you live. Creating spaces for encounters is not only essential for generating social capital, but it also forms the foundation of democratic and collaborative societies.



Fig 7. *Commercial spaces, Umeå city center.*



Fig 8. *Open indoor meeting spaces, Umeå city center.*

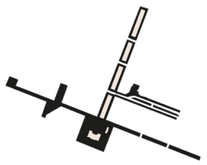


Fig 9. *Outdoor public spaces, winter, Umeå city center.*

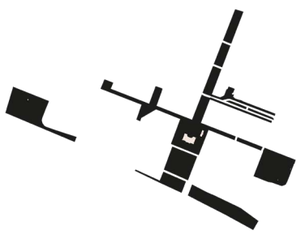


Fig 10. *Outdoor public spaces, summer, Umeå city center.*

Under the theme of participation and citizen engagement, Umeå Municipality has launched several initiatives, among others:

Umecom: A pilot project in 2022 that tested a new form of citizen dialogue, inviting residents to submit ideas they believed would benefit Umeå's development (Umecom n.d.).

Renmarkstorget Digital Survey: A digital platform where citizens could share their opinions about the Renmarkstorget area before the new development of the square (Ståhle & Esaiasson 2023).

Så står det till: The cycling-based citizen dialogue initiative that resulted in the report 'Så står det till' (Umeå Kommun 2020).

These projects represent a shift toward more accessible citizen engagement by bringing dialogue from the city hall into public spaces. However, participatory planning is still not fully embedded in the municipality's core urban development strategies despite growing research highlighting the importance of community involvement for achieving social sustainability and local community cohesion. Without systematic and inclusive mechanisms for public participation, there is a risk that the local perspectives are overlooked. As Umeå continues to grow rapidly, a key question emerges: are the current strategies sufficient to meet social challenges and ensure a development that is truly socially sustainable?

02.

//WHERE WE MEET

SOCIAL INTERVENTIONS

-As exploration and facilitator of change

Over the years, Umeå School of Architecture has had several students conduct exploratory social interventions in the city as part of their master's thesis projects. The implementation and outcomes of these projects can inform and inspire social sustainability efforts in Umeå from a local perspective by proposing interventions aimed at addressing and improving social issues in various ways.

Rum för alla

Rum för alla was a project that aimed to highlight the lack of non-commercial meeting places in the city center by transforming vacant commercial space into collective spaces open to everyone. The project was a part of a master's thesis at Umeå School of Architecture by the students Maja Hallén, Nina Larsson, and Julia Samberg. Rum för alla set up a collaborative space for workshops, conversations, fika, and different kinds of events in a vacant retail space in the Utopia shopping mall in Umeå city center. The space was open to everyone to visit during the opening hours of the mall and became a busy hang-out space in the city center. By opening up a collective space in a commercial mall, the project was questioning the consumerism-centered spatiality of Umeå's city center. Who is this space for, and who has the right to occupy it? Rum för alla eventually had to pack up and leave their space when the property owners got an offer for a pop-up store in the space that Rum för alla had occupied. Ironically, this proves the hypothesis, that consumerism trumps social values. The success of Rum för alla was evident in the busy occupation and the number of activities taking place within the space. The project highlighted and showed the need for non-commercial meeting places in the city where visitors can hang out without needing to consume. Rum för alla successfully established a network of organisations and NGO's involved in the project. They also made several attempts to engage the municipality, suggesting a continuation of the project within one of their properties, but without success. (Hallén, Larsson & Samberg 2017)

Interdine

Interdine, by Gaia Grocella, was a master's thesis project during the year 2018 at Umeå School of Architecture. Interdine is rooted in the intersection of 'interaction' and 'dining,' fostering cross-cultural connections around the dinner table. The project served as a platform of integration by gathering people around the dining table and sharing food. Starting from Grocella's own kitchen, the project gradually expanded to involve actors and organisations working with refugees and integrational aspects, thus creating an encounter around a meal where the architect acts as a host aimed to give agency to others. The shared meals then evolved into a series of discursive dinners that took place in different spaces in Umeå city center, involving both organisations as well as anyone who wanted to participate, applying an interdisciplinary methodology to bring the conversation to the public domain. Grocella proposed a permanent interdine setting in the city center at the culture house of Väven, claiming spaces for cross-cultural encounters with a restaurant run by refugees and locals together. The restaurant would be a space for workshops, cooking classes and discursive dinners. What this project successfully did was to initiate social and integrational processes within the framework of sharing a meal. By gathering around a common activity, new bonds were created and integrational processes initiated. (Grocella 2018)

What these projects successfully show is that socially engaged architectural interventions can play a vital role in challenging dominant urban narratives, fostering inclusion, and initiating meaningful social and cultural processes, whether by creating accessible, non-commercial public spaces like Rum för alla, or by using shared activities such as dining together in Interdine to promote integration and dialogue across different cultures.



Fig 11. *Interdine project by Gaia Grocella. Image: @Gaia Grocella*

THE COMMUNITY WAGON

-Constructing a social situation

Miessen (2024) states that practice, as an action, involves the introduction of an element into the world without knowing the outcome. This introduced element serves as both a research tool and a speculative insertion to investigate its potential social and political impact. He further argues that test-bed practices, as a research methodology, allow explorations free from fixed expectations, which in turn fosters dialogue, creating a space for discussion, and ultimately reveals patterns and social responses that could inform spatial practice. In the same way, the Situationists advocated for the concept of constructed situations. A constructed situation is an attempt to break free from the constraints imposed by the built environment and the spectacle of modern society. It is a carefully orchestrated moment that disrupts the monotony of everyday life, creating a transient yet authentic experience where spontaneity and imagination triumph over the rationality of space. The situationists argue that it is within such a situation that individuals can find brief glimpses of truth and reality free from the influence of what is referred to as the spectacle. These moments offer an opportunity to engage with the world in a more direct and unfiltered way, challenging the passive consumption of experiences and fostering genuine human interaction (Encyclopaedia Brittanica 2024; Sadler 1999)

To investigate and embed myself within the social fabric of Umeå, I constructed a mobile unit, the community wagon. This architectural artifact is equipped with a foldable table, chairs, a bench, and a serving surface, and is moved through the city by bicycle. Functioning as a mobile community hub, the wagon becomes a focal point wherever it is placed, temporarily activating its surroundings. Positioning the wagon in socially passive and underutilized spaces creates a new, however temporary, social space that encourages interaction by inviting passers-by to a fika. The wagon itself, with its bright pink exterior, invokes curiosity and challenges the routine flow of everyday life, creating an opportunity for unexpected exchange to take place. At the heart of the wagon is the Hej Café, which is set up at each stop to offer people coffee and conversation. Through this gesture, the wagon constructs social situations, disrupting the patterns of everyday life, and connecting people in a shared moment of conversation and coffee. By deliberately placing the wagon in unexpected

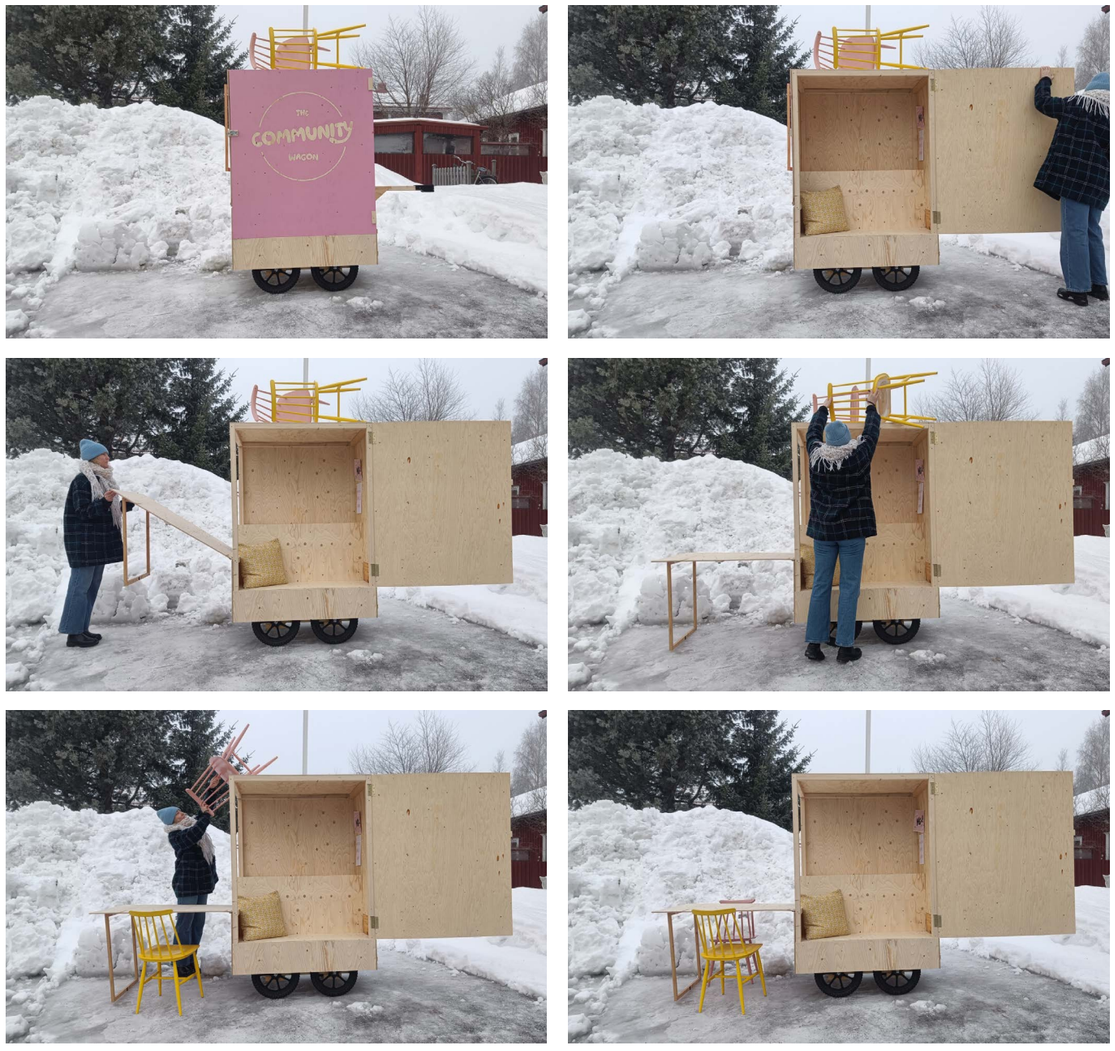


Fig 12. *Unfolding The Community Wagon.*

situations, in the middle of a bridge or at the local recycling station, the wagon disrupts familiar patterns of everyday life and stimulates social interactions. This situation reveals the social potential of overlooked spaces by intervening in a place and catalyzing something that did not previously exist. The wagon invites us to rethink the relationship with the urban fabric and the social potential that is embedded within it.

NOTES FROM EXPLORATION
- Situations of encounters

Placement:
Walkway along the river. Lundåkern. Sunday, Nov 24, 2024, 12.40. -15° c

...Quite a lot of people were out walking. I offered passersby some fika and asked them what their thoughts were about community cohesion and the neighbourhoods physical environment. ... One woman wished for spaces for urban gardening and another one for intergenerational meeting places. At one point, several others joined an ongoing discussion, creating a collective exchange of ideas...

Placement:
The local recycling station, Hedlunda. Sunday, Jan 23, 2025, 11.10. -5° c

...Setting up at the recycling station next to the green containers felt a bit awkward. The location was chosen not because of its beauty but because it is not a place where you expect to find a bright pink wagon and someone offering coffee and conversation ...The recyclers dropped by one by one. Everyone who visited the station had a positive reaction and wanted a quick cup of coffee. The sheer unexpectedness of me and my wagon's presence seemed to lower the threshold for the social interactions...

Placement:
Lundabron. Bölesholmarna. Monday, Jan 27, 2025, 11.30, +1° c

A foggy Monday, lunchtime... I set up my wagon in the middle of the bridge, folding down the table, putting down the chairs, and opening up the doors... My time at the bridge is busy, a lot of curiosity, people asking questions, and having a cup of coffee before continuing their walk. A general sense of positivity... The conversations revolved around different topics, but many people wanted to know more about my project and the construction of the wagon...

Placement:
City hall, Umeå centrum. Friday, Jan 31, 2025, 12.05. -5° c

... Lunchtime, and busy with people going in and out of the city hall, I placed myself next to the walkway in between the flow from the busy bicycle path and the path to the parking lot... I started to seek contact with people, greeting them and asking if I could offer some fika. Unfortunately, no one showed any interested engaging in conversation. Usually, the wagon is an object of curiosity ... But not here at the city hall... I started to feel quite exposed and uncomfortable... I stayed at my spot for a while longer before declaring the mission of conversing with people outside the city hall futile...

Placement:
Outside of UMA. Konstnärligt campus. Friday, Jan 31, 2025, 13.15. -5° c

I parked my wagon outside of UMA while I was getting coffee with a friend in curiosum. We were sitting next to the window overlooking the space where I parked my wagon... there was a constant flow of people stopping by the wagon, looking at it, and talking for a while. Some were taking pictures and the pink wagon was creating reactions and became a focal point for curiosity and conversation even when I was not present.



Fig 13. *Lundabron.*



Fig 14. *Recycling station, Hedlunda.*



Fig 15. *City hall.*



Fig 16. *UMA.*

SUMMARY OF FINDINGS

-Lessons learned from the wagon

(Not?) All spaces have the potential to become socially active spaces.
An architectural intervention can activate socially passive spaces. However, in this experiment, some spaces, such as outside the city hall, were unsuccessfully activated, indicating that some spaces have a higher threshold.

The wagon, as an artifact, has the potential to create a social space within itself.
When parking the wagon, with its bright pink color, it invokes curiosity and becomes in itself a conversation piece.

The social space created with the wagon is transient and fleeting.
The social space created when parking the wagon is temporary. Upon leaving, the space once again becomes a socially passive space.

The disruption of everyday life generates social situations.
When disrupting the rhythm of everyday life, for example, by placing a pink café wagon at the local recycling station, a situation occurs that would not have happened otherwise.

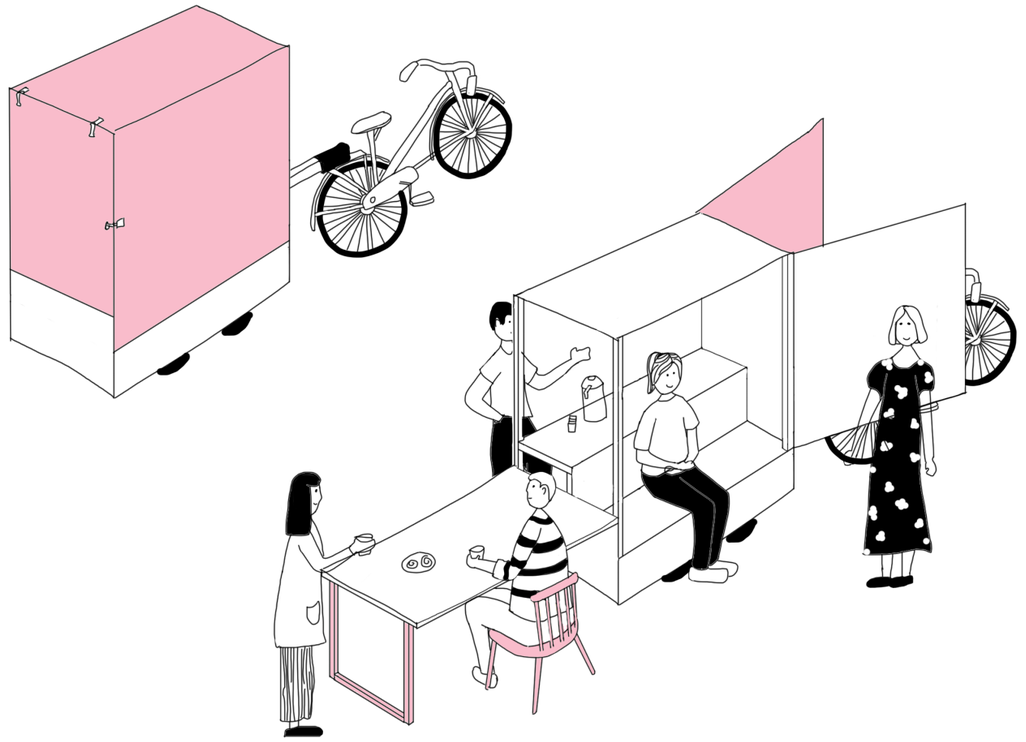


Fig 17. *Illustration of The Community Wagon*

03.

//WHEN WE MEET

THE HUB

- Building geographies of encounters

Addressing social sustainability and generation of social capital requires interventions and efforts targeting both the local context as well as the larger city scale. Targeted interventions and physical improvements in urban development often risk becoming isolated and limited to specific sites or neighborhoods. Due to financial constraints at the municipal level, it can prove a challenge to establish permanent, socially stimulating meeting spaces consistently across the city. However, by actively involving residents in improvement processes and fostering collective engagement, sustainable changes can be achieved without relying solely on municipal resources. Empowering residents to take initiative in enhancing their local environments and creating attractive public spaces could strengthen social capital by encouraging new relationships and collaborations, and thus contributing to community sustainability. Attractive meeting places also offer the potential to host activities that attract people from different parts of the city, increasing human interaction and promoting bridging social capital, which is vital in combating spatial segregation. To support these processes of change and encourage local engagement, I propose a movable meeting space, *The Hub,* that would serve as a community incubator and a catalyst for civic participation during a defined period. The Hub would act as a community space that moves within the city of Umeå, assembled at different locations to spark new relationships and generate social capital within and between neighborhoods. The hub focuses on placemaking and neighbourhood development by functioning as a meeting place and a connector between local organizations, services, and residents. Through the Hub, community groups can form to initiate activities and events, lead grassroots initiatives, and placemaking efforts. Over a four-year cycle, the Hub establishes itself in a location, activating the space through a wide range of events, workshops, and gatherings. Most importantly, it functions as a neighborhood living room, welcoming people to drop in for a coffee, repair their bikes at the workshop, hang out, or join local groups and organised activities.

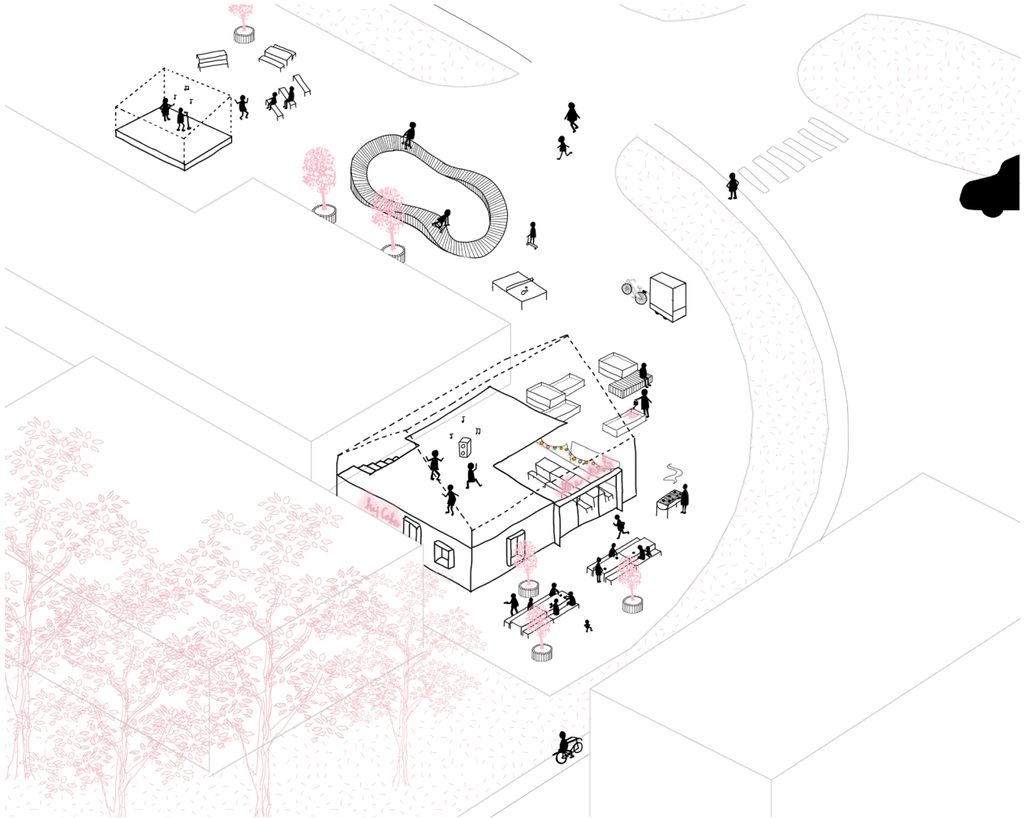
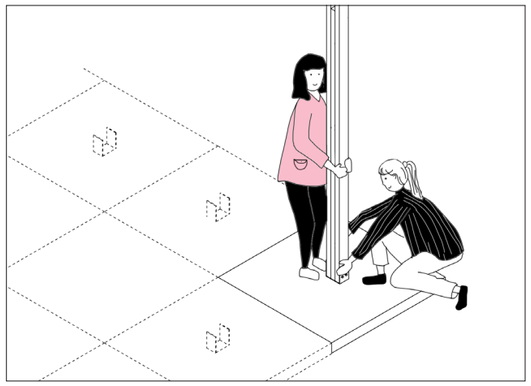
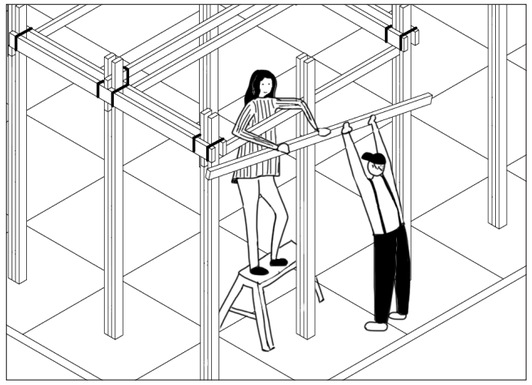
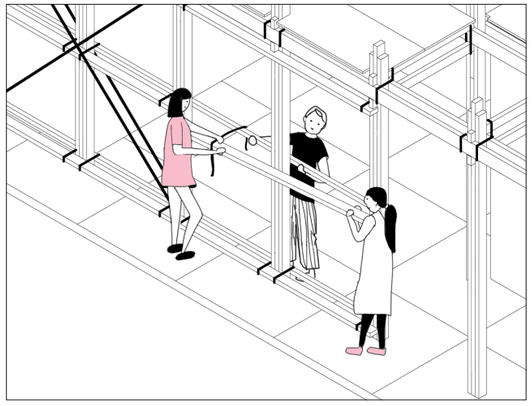


Fig 18. *Illustration of the hub*







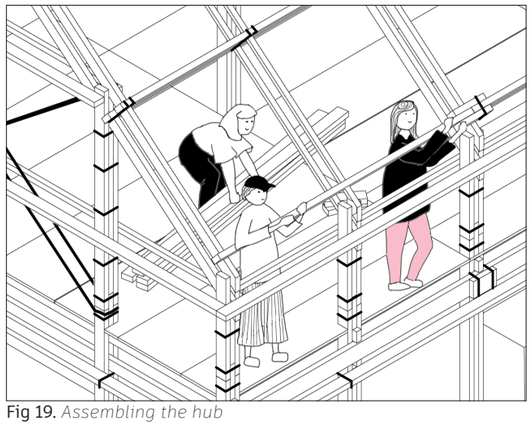


Fig 19. *Assembling the hub*

The Hub is designed for easy assembly, disassembly, and relocation, making it a flexible solution for activating public spaces without the limitations typically associated with permanent structures, such as land ownership, permits, or ongoing maintenance. As a temporary meeting point, The Hub enriches the urban environment while drawing attention to the role of social interaction and community engagement in shaping inclusive city spaces. The Hub is a timber-framed structure clad in polycarbonate panels, incorporating insulated modules that house the Hej! café, kitchen, toilet, and workshop. Designed as a nature house, it combines a passively heated greenhouse environment with insulated spaces for year-round use. The building components are assembled using tension straps instead of conventional screws and nails, supporting a circular construction approach where materials can be borrowed, returned undamaged, or reused in future projects. The wooden structure is designed for on-site assembly by community members, guided by a project manager or community architect, and minimizes the requirement of heavy machinery or power tools. The exceptions are the concrete foundation slabs and insulated modules which must be lifted into place by a crane. The construction method not only makes the process of building more approachable but also invites the community to collaborate, fostering a shared sense of ownership and cooperation already in the initial phase. Residents in the neighborhood are then given the opportunity to organize activities, build structures, and personalize the building to create a unique, place-specific identity for the hub. The goal is for the community to develop co-ownership of the building and the surrounding space, transforming it into a vibrant place that encourages activity, creativity, and social interaction.

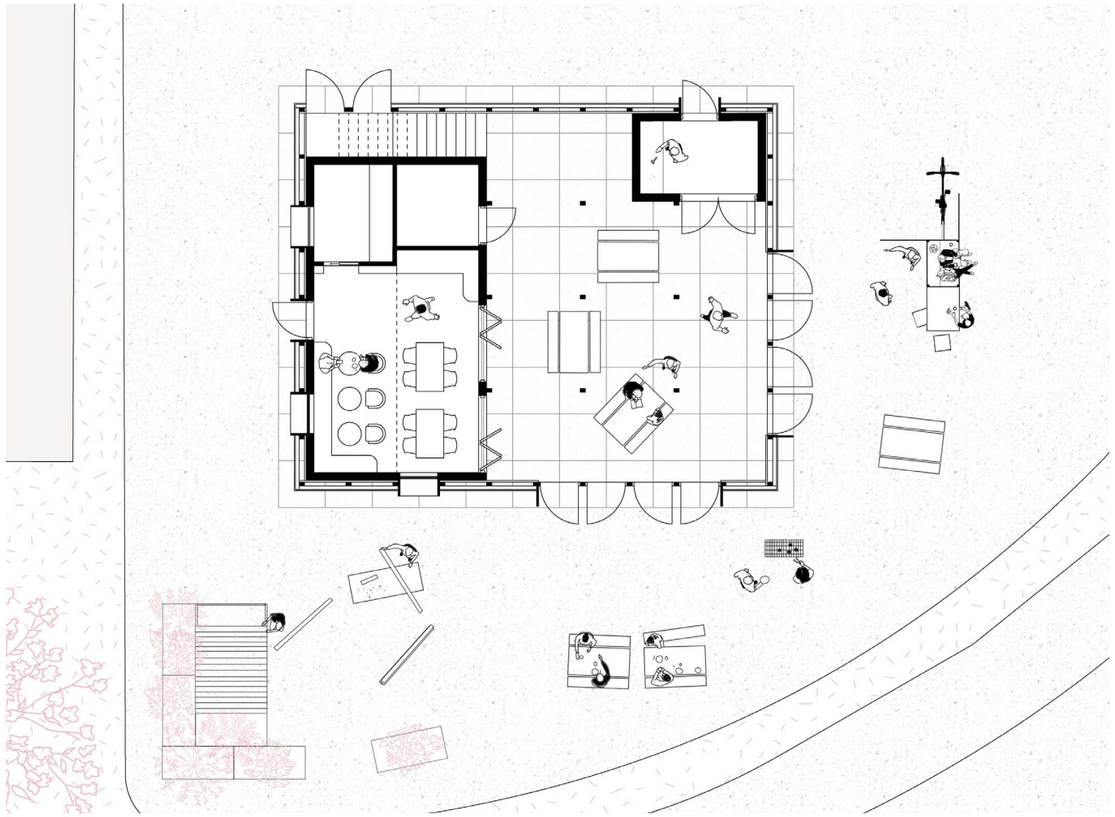


Fig 20. *Plan drawing*

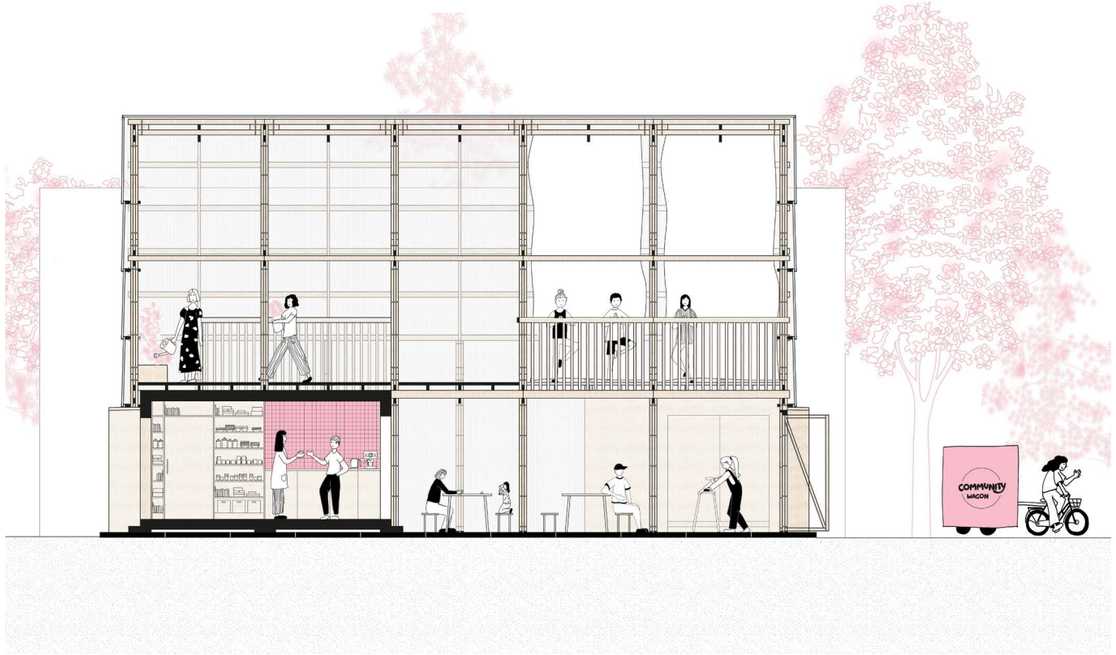


Fig 21. *Section*

MANAGING THE HUB

- Timeframe, operation and management

The Hub operates on a four-year cycle, beginning with an initial site analysis, followed by assembly, active use, disassembly, and relocation to a new site where the process then starts again. This timeframe of four years allows for a thorough understanding of the local context during the first year, followed by three years of operation. These three years provide the community with the opportunity to develop their own agenda, build the community structure, and experiment with different initiatives. A longer timeframe risks causing fatigue and loss of momentum in the project, while a shorter one may rush the process, limiting the residents' ability to fully explore and realize their ideas.

The preparations begin before the structure is assembled on site. What role should the Hub play in this particular neighborhood? What are the interests of the local community? Which organizations and initiatives might want to be involved? What plans does Umeå Municipality already have for the area? And where is the most suitable location to place the Hub? Answering these questions requires local knowledge, held by the people, organizations, and actors who live and operate in the area, making it crucial to invite residents to participate and spark public interest in the project. During the early phase, the Community Wagon serves as a key tool for gathering insights and sparking curiosity. To build trust and make the wagon a recognizable presence in the neighborhood, this phase must be allowed to unfold gradually, with regular visits and ongoing engagement. The goal is to identify and establish relationships with local organizations, initiatives, and inhabitants, and to identify spaces that can be activated as part of the Hub's future presence.

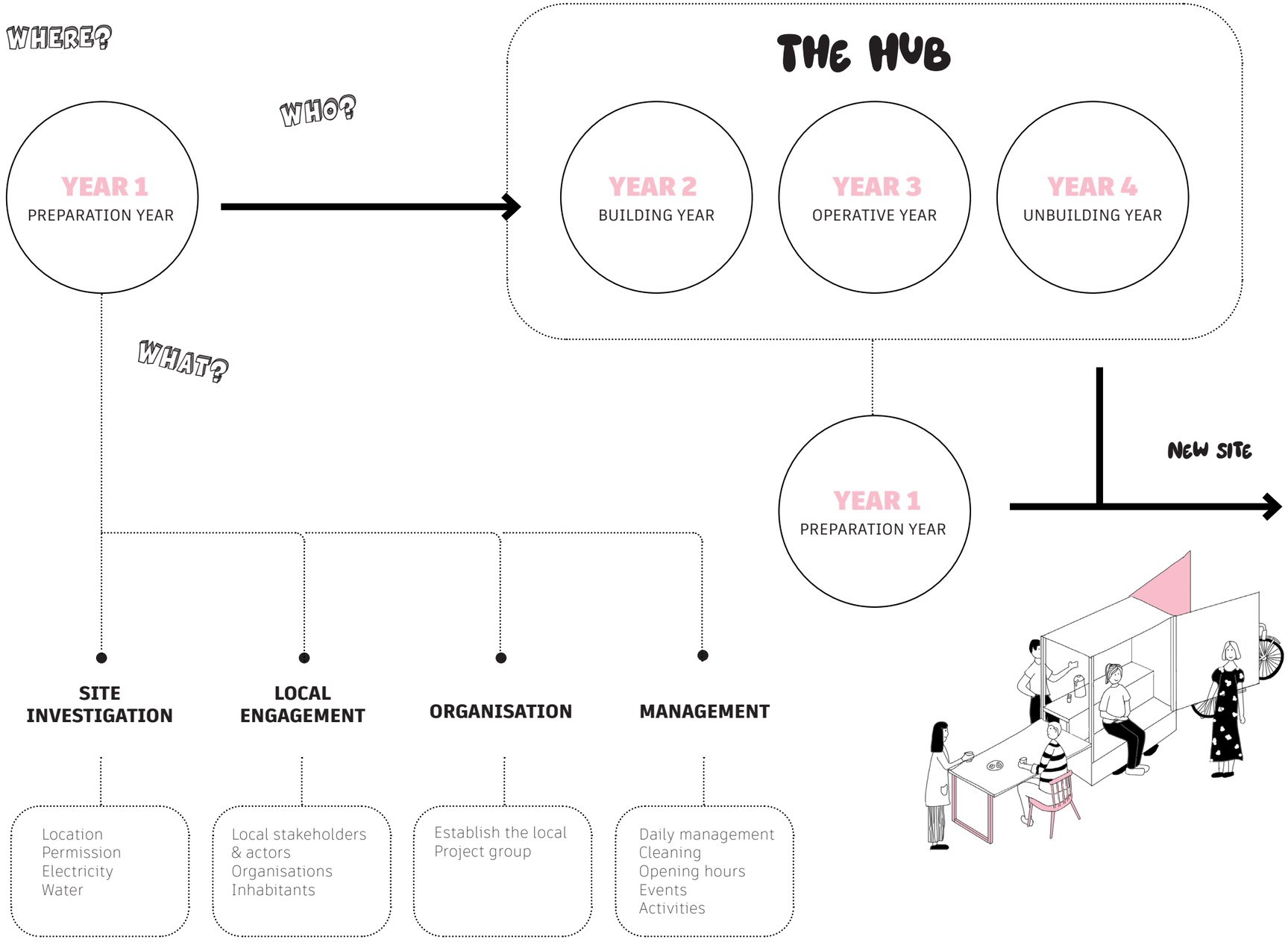


Fig 22. *Diagram of timeline*

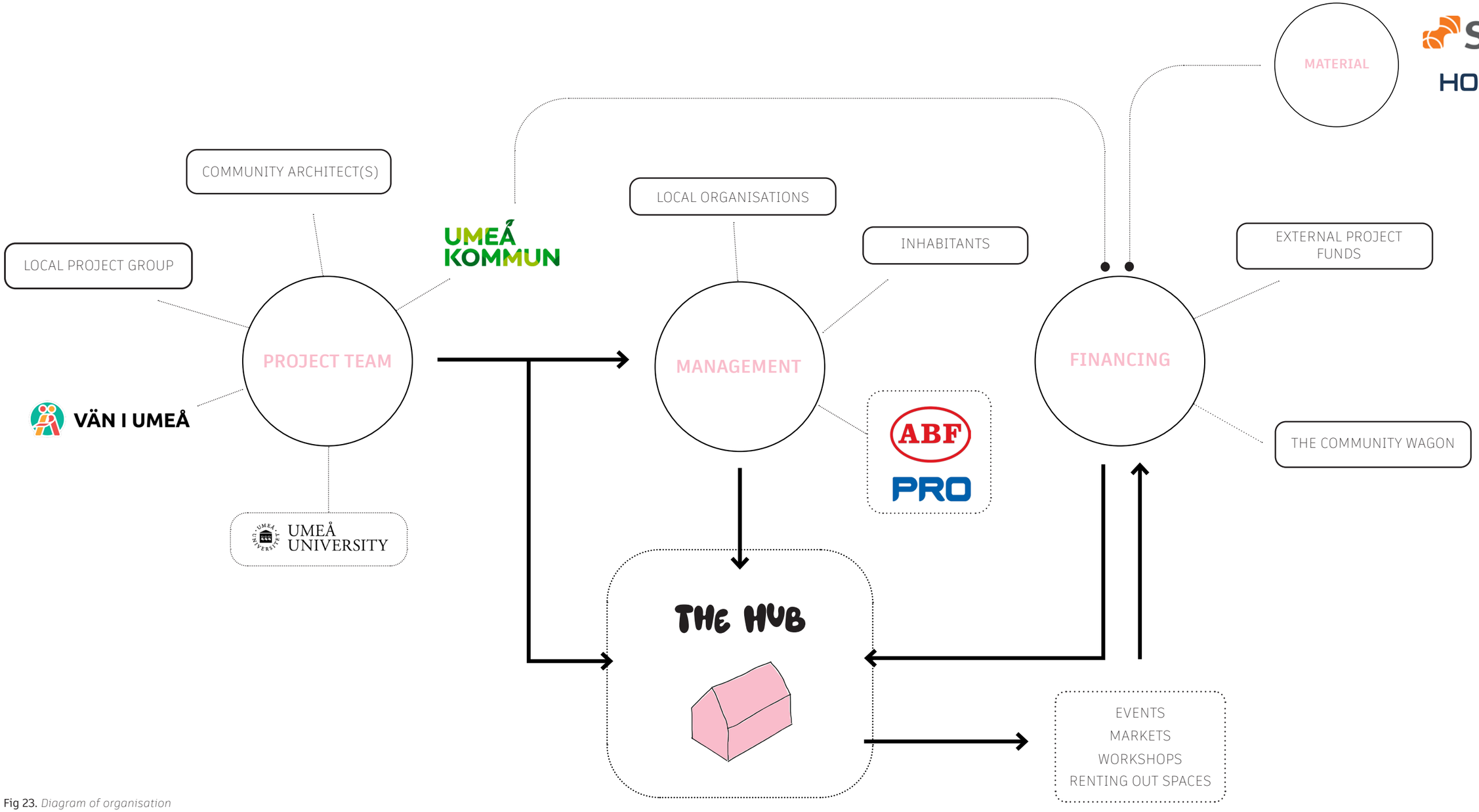


Fig 23. *Diagram of organisation*

To ensure a viable system for operation, a clear structure for responsibility and ongoing maintenance is essential. The initiative is led by a project team consisting of a community architect, local representatives, and key stakeholders such as Umeå Municipality and Vän i Umeå. This group is responsible for the overall planning and maintaining communication with local groups and organizations. During the first preparatory year, the structure for the daily operations and maintenance of The Hub will be mapped out and organized. Which local organizations and actors might be interested in taking part? To ensure a vibrant and active space with a continuous presence throughout the day, week, and months, it is important to engage actors willing to contribute to programming and events. This could include organizing parent groups, meetings with senior associations such as PRO, homework help sessions, and other community-based activities. By organizing events, markets, workshops, etc, for the public, the hub could also generate income that helps maintain the management.

CONCLUSION

This thesis has explored the intersection of architectural design and social sustainability, with a focus on how the built environment can foster social capital, inclusivity, and community cohesion. Through theoretical analysis, policy review, and spatial experimentation, it is evident that architecture and urban design play an important role in shaping the conditions for community cohesion. While Umeå demonstrates a generally high level of social capital and trust, the municipal approach remains focused on overarching strategies, lacking the local perspective needed to create a grounded understanding of the social fabric in Umeås neighbourhood. This top-down planning risks falling short of achieving social sustainability by overlooking the local conditions and community aspects. The Community Wagon and The Hub are showing how small-scale, temporary, and participatory interventions can activate public life in urban spaces. These projects do not claim to solve the structural issues, but rather aim to initiate and establish geographies of encounters, belonging, and community engagement. Importantly, the findings indicate that physical space in itself cannot generate social sustainability. It is important to include processes of participation, community engagement, as well as practices of care and collaboration to build social capital and a sustainable neighbourhood development over time. More research is needed to explore how improvements in the local environment influence social capital and to understand the role of community engagement in this process. Is it the transformation of the physical environment that drives change, or is it the act of residents coming together to address issues and lead development efforts that leads to increased social capital and community cohesion? Future work should also focus on deepening the participatory aspects and developing methods for measuring the social impact of architectural interventions over time. This thesis advocates for a more democratic, community-focused focused and socially attuned practice by considering the architect not only as a designer of physical space, but also as a facilitator of community and local engagement.



Fig 24. *Collage*

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